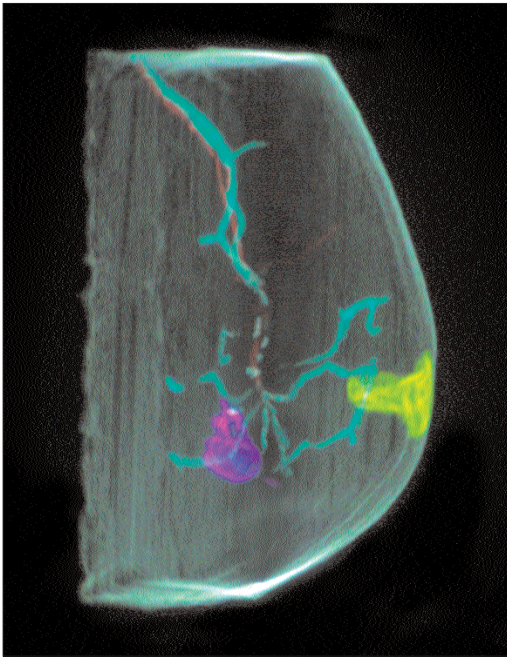




The Perspecta Spatial 3D System displaying a breast tumour. Medical researchers and surgeons benefit tremendously from 3D views

*Image courtesy of Actuality Systems Inc.,
Bedford, MA, USA © 2004 David Shoppen*

2002, electronics giant Sharp, together with Japanese telecoms operator NTT DoCoMo, launched a mobile phone with a tiny 3D LCD screen, and more than 2 million units have been sold. And in November of 2003, Sharp released a notebook computer with a 15-inch LCD screen that can switch between 2D and 3D viewing modes.

“All” we want right now is for such systems to be scalable in terms of size, and for them to become cheaper. For technological reasons, it will be several years before something like the Perspecta Spatial 3D System can be hooked up to a PlayStation or Xbox. Also, the display technology needs to improve—at present, full-resolution images are displayed in only eight colours, and brightness and contrast could be improved. And, of course, there’s the issue of raw computational power—but of which, of course, we can be assured that we’ll get up to speed in a few years.

With goggles and a degradation of overall experience, it may not be that far off: Actuality Systems says it might build lightweight versions of the 3D display that could be marketed to consumers for use with video game consoles. CTO Gregg Favalora says the company has plans to begin work on such a display. Favalora also says, “Component costs will decrease. There could be a desktop unit in the future.”

And here’s the interesting part for all you gamers reading this: Actuality Systems has produced an SDK for Perspecta that is an extension of Mesa—the open-source implementation of OpenGL—which could open up gaming possibilities. In which case, true-3D *DOOM 3* could well be something you’ll play in your lifetime! ☒

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